

Concept Fan



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The Concept Fan takes ideas and expands them greater in scope, and then reexamines them in further detail. It builds a map or a fan of concepts that reside in the space near the originating concept or idea. One simply builds a hierarchical tree, starting at any point on the tree. Move upward to the next more general concept, then branch back down in parallel and further specificity to other related concepts. Build the tree at random, and as ideas appear interesting and worth expanding the branches, or finding the thicker, more general base branches.

Co-evolution of the problem and solution!

It is very easy when trying to think creatively to end up with the obvious ideas that don't really help. Edward de Bono developed the 'Concept Fan' technique of taking a step back to get a broader perspective and thereby a new view of the problem and new ways of solving the problem.

Concept Fan:

1. To start a Concept Fan, draw a circle on a large piece of paper (A3 paper or White Board), just right of centre. Write the problem you are trying to solve into it. To the right of it radiate lines representing possible solutions to the problem. As shown in Figure 1 below.



Figure 1: First stage of a Concept Fan

2. It may be that the first ideas generated are impractical, unremarkable, or do not really solve the problem. If this is the case, take a 'step back' for a broader view of the problem. Do this by drawing a circle to the left of the first circle, and write the broader definition into this new circle. Link it with an arrow to show that it comes from the first circle as in Figure 2.

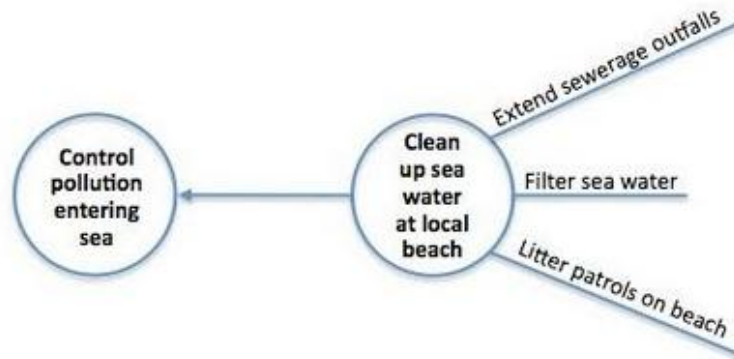


Figure 2: Broadening the problem definition on a Concept Fan

3. Use this as the starting point to radiate out new ideas as in Figure 3.

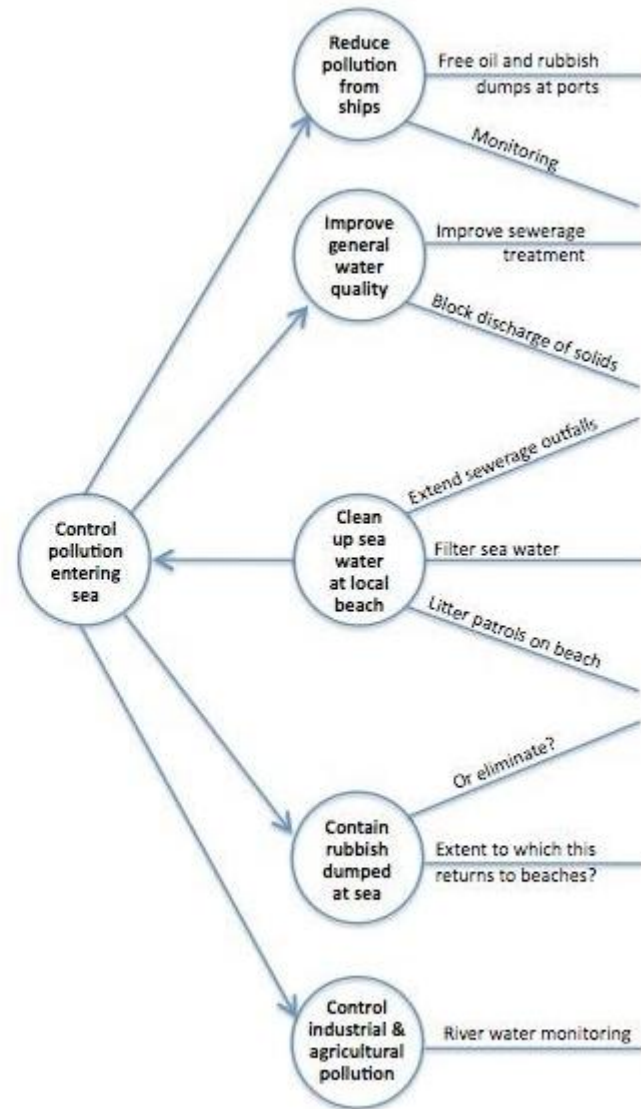


Figure 3: Generating ideas from a broader definition of the problem

4. If this does not give you the idea you are looking for then repeat the process and take another step back as in Figure 4.

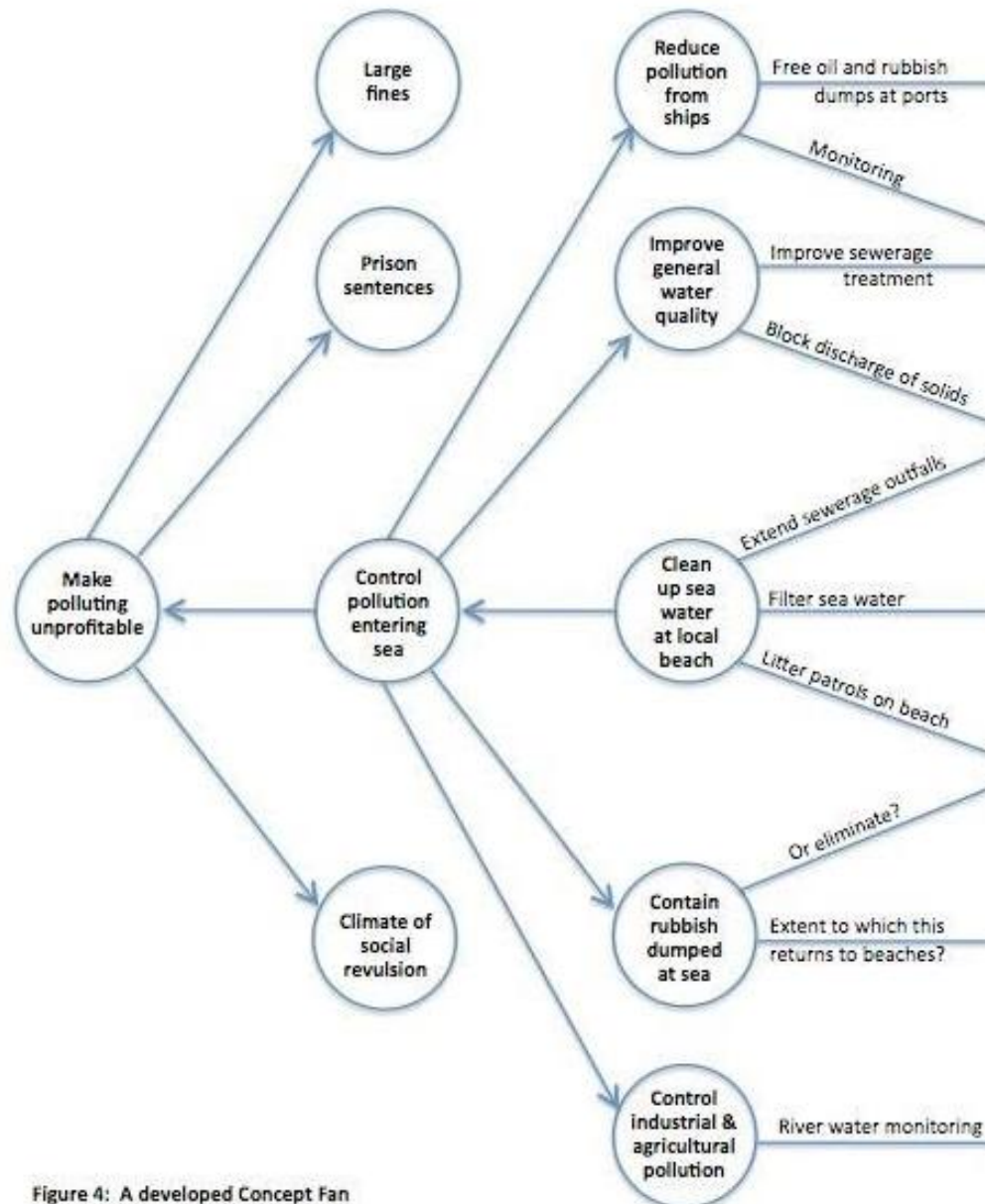


Figure 4: A developed Concept Fan

Business Example

Problem: People are not coming on time to office. When asked people talk about traffic issues, long commutes, work taking them to different parts of town etc. etc.

What are the ideas here? Mark people absent, put a fine, change the timing etc etc.

Now go back to basics. Why should people come on time? You get the concepts: people can coordinate better with each other at work if everyone is there at the same time., People spend the required amount of time at work. Now what is the main concept that you would like to focus on - say it is 'People can co-ordinate better' Now do people have to always be coordinating their work, do people have to be present at the same location for coordination?

Now based on this analysis one could come to a conclusion that perhaps every day the team needs to touch base at least once for coordination and updates, preferably the team needs to work from the same space and spend a lot of time together so that softer issues can be better handled and facilitate smoother communications. So the idea from this could be 1) flexible office hours but with fixed time in a day when everyone needs to be present either physically or over conference call, and have the main base of work for everyone in the same office space, so that people interact and meet each other often to smoothen communications.